MEMBER GUIDES · C6D

Your year as Senior Deacon

The Master’s messenger, and the Brother who conducts candidates through their Passing and Raising. A short guide to the year.

For	The Brother about to be invested as Senior Deacon, and his Personal Mentor
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · One of six Officer Guides, Steward to Senior Warden. The office is described here; the words and floorwork are learned at the Lodge of Instruction, never from a document.

1 What the office is

The Senior Deacon sits at the right of the Worshipful Master. He carries messages and communications from the Master to the Senior Warden, and conducts the candidate in the Second and Third Degrees. He is also, in practice, the senior of the two Deacons: the one the Junior Deacon looks to on the floor, and the one the DC relies on when the ceremony is long.

Your jewel	A dove bearing an olive branch, as for the Junior Deacon. Your wand, like his, is a working tool of the office: carried, grounded and handed with care.

2 What you will actually do

- Learn the floorwork of the Second and Third Degrees thoroughly. The Third in particular has moments where the candidate depends entirely on you, and where confidence matters more than anywhere else in the Craft.
- Prepare the candidate practically with his Personal Mentor: what the evening will ask of him physically, that it is safe, symbolic and dignified, and that you will be beside him throughout.
- Attend to the Master: communications, the ballot, whatever he needs on the floor.
- Lead the Junior Deacon kindly. You were in his chair a year ago.
- If your Lodge works the Traditional History or the Charges by delegation, this is a year in which you may be asked to learn a longer piece. Say yes to what you can and no to what you cannot.

3 What to learn, and how

- The Third Degree floorwork is the hardest in the Craft to do well and the most rewarding. Take as many Lodge of Instruction evenings as the Preceptor will give you.
- Visit two or three Lodges and watch their Senior Deacons at a Raising. You will see things done differently, and some of them better.
- Start on the Junior Warden’s work in the second half of the year: it is spoken, not walked, and it is a different kind of learning.
- Little and often. Ten minutes a day, out loud, beats an hour on the night before.
- Understand it before you memorise it. Words that mean something stay; words that are only sound go under pressure.
- Record it and listen in the car. Then record yourself and listen to that.

4 Things nobody tells you

- Visiting Brethren notice the Deacons before anyone else. A quiet, unhurried pair on the floor is what makes a Lodge’s ceremonies admired.
- The Senior Deacon is the Brother best placed to notice a candidate who is frightened. Say so to his mentor, and to the DC, before the night.
- Rule 172: there must be at least four weeks between a candidate’s degrees. If your Lodge is planning two ceremonies close together, the DC and Secretary will know; you do not need to.

5 The time it takes

As Junior Deacon, with a longer learning curve for the Third Degree: one meeting a month, the Lodge of Instruction most weeks, and steady learning in the weeks before a Raising.

6 Who will help

Your Personal Mentor	Still yours. Office does not end mentoring; it changes the conversation. Tell him if the learning is not going well, or the diary.
The Director of Ceremonies	Owns the ceremonies and the floor. He will tell you what your Lodge does, which is what matters; Lodges differ.
The Preceptor and the LoI	Where the office is learned. Go even in the weeks when there is nothing for you to do.
The Lodge Mentor	Watches the office queue for the whole Lodge: nobody pushed before he is ready, nobody left waiting. Say so to him if either is happening to you.
The Province	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk, the monthly mentoring call on the first Tuesday at 7pm, and Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk), which has a paper on every office.

7 Looking ahead

Junior Warden, usually: your first year in the principal officers' chairs and the first with the Festive Board in your care. The Master will discuss it with you before the Installation.

> **For your mentor.** Three questions for the conversation before the Installation: Does he want this office this year, and has he said so to his family? What is the one piece he is worried about, and who will help him with it? What will we do together in the second half of the year to make the next office feel easy?
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> **Readiness, not pressure, in either direction.** Nobody should take an office before he feels able, and nobody capable should be left waiting. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

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